

The question that broke him.



A Meta interview story.

And what it teaches about MAANG in 2026.

Frameworks · Fine-tuning · LangGraph · LoRA · DPO

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T H E S T O R Y

Last week, my friend called me
after a Meta interview.

"I bombed it."

Two weeks of prep.
Solid resume.
He'd built RAG systems.
He'd used LoRA in production.

On paper, he was ready.

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The interviewer said:

//

*You said you fine-tuned
with LoRA on your resume.*

*Why rank 16 and not 8?
What target modules did you pick?*

*How did you validate against
catastrophic forgetting?*

— MAANG interviewer, last week

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He knew the words.

He couldn't defend
the choices.

Rejection email.

That same night.

He'd used LoRA.

He couldn't explain how it worked.

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T H I S I S E V E R Y W H E R E

**Everyone knows
the terminology.**

**Almost nobody knows
the mechanics.**

*Senior MAANG interviewers spot
this in the first 3 questions.*

The rest of the loop is polite closure.

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The LoRA question

Two answers. Same words. Different outcomes.

WHAT HE SAID

"We used LoRA."

*"Rank 16 seemed
to work fine."*

"Metrics went up."

*"I don't recall
the target modules."*

- *Freeze. Rejection.*

WHAT THEY WANTED

$$W = W_0 + BA$$

r=16 · target Q, V only

Intrinsic rank hypothesis
(Hu et al., 2021)

MMLU: 79.5 → 79.3 ✓

IFEval regression: clean

Replay data at 20%

- *Papers. Numbers. Offer.*

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Frameworks + Fine-tuning

73+ questions · MAANG staff+ bar

01 Deep Conceptual

LoRA math, DPO derivation,
catastrophic forgetting, LangGraph internals

02 Technical Coding

Implement LoRA from scratch, DPO loss,
chat templates + loss masking

03 System Design

Multi-tenant LoRA serving,
framework abstraction layers

04 Behavioral

Fine-tune degraded quality,
agent misfires in production

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THE COMEBACK

Same person. Different depth.
Two weeks later — he got the offer.

The repo he studied from:

[github.com / JoshithReddyAleti](https://github.com/JoshithReddyAleti/AI_Engineer_Interview_Prep)
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Week 6 →

SRITHU GADDOLLA

The reason this series exists.

Every late night. Every 2 AM debug.

Every idea I doubted before she said:

"Build the resource you wished you had."

If this helps you — thank her.

Every kind word goes to Srithu.